Chapter 1: The Unusual Carnival Attraction

Dallin, Neal, and Bryant ran up to a small building at the amusement park they were at.

“I win!” Dallin announced as he touched the rope that indicated where the line started.

“It wasn’t a contest,” Neal corrected, “and I might have beaten you if you’d told me we were racing. I am on the track team.” He looked like he could be a runner. He had light brown hair, a runner’s build, and seemed pretty strong.

“Everything is a contest,” Dallin assured him. Dallin too seemed pretty fit. He had darker hair, but he seemed on Neal’s level physically.

Bryant, the shortest of them, rolled his eyes, and asked, “What is this place, and why is there no line?”

That was a good question. The amusement park was very crowded that day, but there was no line at all at the attraction. It was at the back corner of the park. Still, it seemed odd that they didn’t have to wait.

There was no one working at the attraction, but there wasn’t a barrier to keep them out.

“Should we go in?” Dallin asked.

“We don’t even know what this place is,” Neal pointed out.

Dallin looked up. The sign on the building read *The House of Dreams.* Under it, it said, “If we shadows have offended,

think but this, and all is mended, that you have but slumbered here, while these visions did appear. And this weak and idle theme, no more yielding but a dream."

"What?" Bryant asked. "I know what the Fun House is, and what the House of Mirrors is, but I've never heard of a House of Dreams before." He scrunched his eyebrows.

A voice responded, "It's Shakespeare."

The boys looked over to see who was talking. It was Izzy. She was walking up with Olivia. Izzy had long, curly brown hair and a happy, round face. Olivia had straight, light brown hair and was very thin and tall. Dallin, Neal, and Bryant knew both girls, as both girls were in the same middle school they were. All of them were in eighth grade.

Izzy continued, "It's a quote from Shakespeare, from *A Midsummer Night's Dream*. Puck the fairy says those words. If we shadows have offended..."

"What's it doing on an attraction at an amusement park?" Neal asked.

Dallin shrugged. "I don't know, but should we go in? There is no wait in line."

"Maybe it's someplace we can rest," Olivia suggested. "I am tired from walking around all day. Do you think the place encourages good dreams? What if we have nightmares?"

"There's one way to find out," Bryant pointed out. "Let's go in. I'm not afraid."

"I'll go first," Dallin offered.

He opened the door and stepped in. The others followed.

The House of Dreams was not like any carnival attraction they'd ever seen before. It was a single room with chests all around it.

"What's in the chests?" Izzy asked.

Dallin walked over to one, his curiosity stronger than his caution, and opened it. "Clothes," he answered disappointingly. "Why would there be a room with a chest of clothes?"

"Perhaps the others have other items," Neal suggested. "I could enjoy a chest full of weapons."

"I'd prefer cash," Bryant teased.

Olivia opened a chest. It was full of costume jewelry, likely cheap but very pretty. She stared at it and gawked, "Wow! That would make me feel pretty."

"You are pretty," Bryant assured her. He looked over at Izzy and noted, "You are too. Shall we see what is in the other chests?"

Neal opened the next chest. It had cowboy hats, bandannas, and several aprons. He picked up a cowboy hat and put it on.

As soon as he did, the air around them began to sparkle. They could see nothing for a moment but the shimmering light.

When it cleared, they were in what looked to be a western town from the 1800s.

"How did we get here?" Neal asked, looking down at his clothes and seeing that they were authentic cowboy clothes. He even had a gun-belt with a gun in it.

He pulled it out and exclaimed, “This is a 44 caliber Colt peacemaker! This dream is incredibly accurate. It was a very popular gun in the wild west.”

“Is it real?” Dallin asked, stepping back from him. “This is an odd dream.”

Neal knew gun safety very well, and he was a good shot. His father had taught him. He pointed the gun away from the others and shot it at a cactus. A chunk of the cactus blew off where he hit it. “It’s real,” he announced. “I will be careful with it.”

The others looked at their clothes. They didn’t have guns, but Bryant had a whip, which he had no idea how to use. Dallin had a lasso.

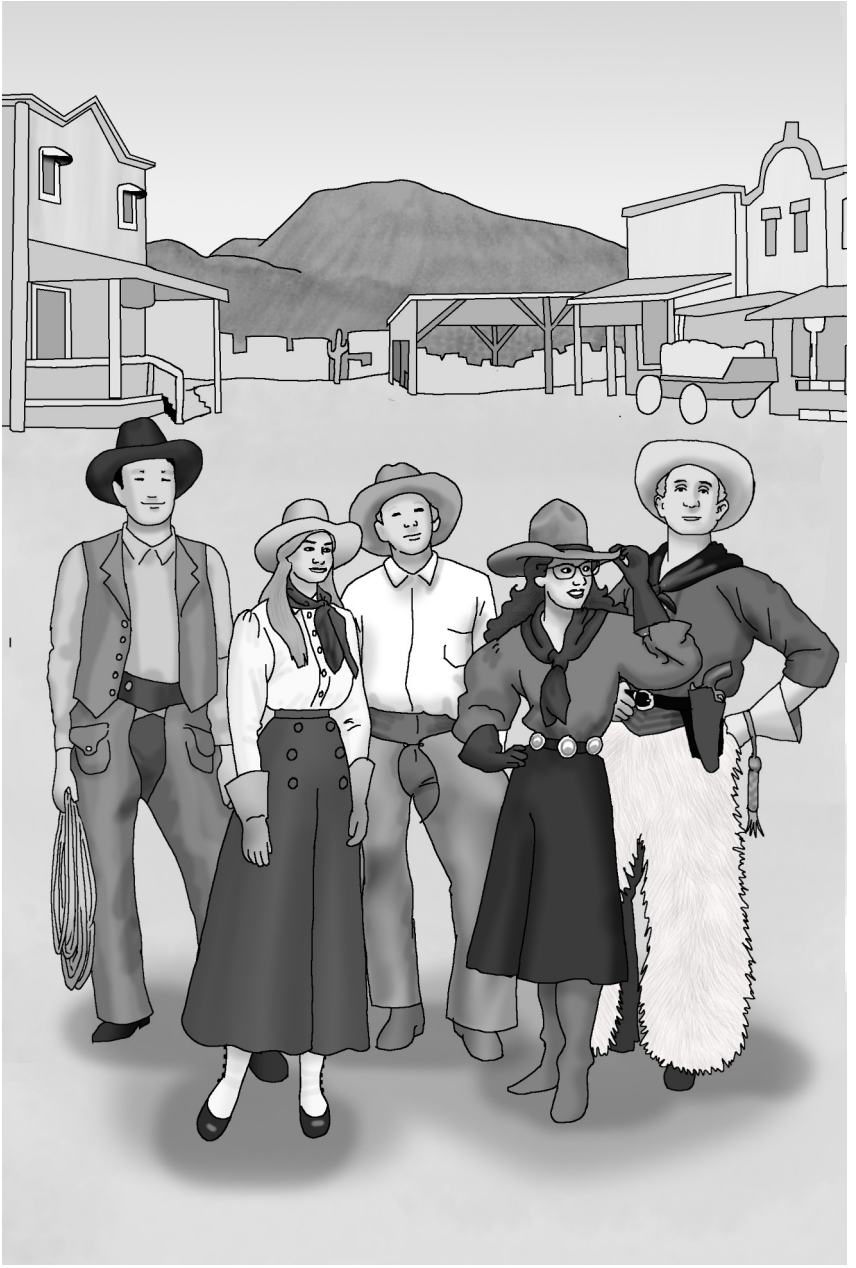
“This is one odd dream,” Olivia noted, the fear in her voice obvious. “Dreams aren’t supposed to have real weapons in them. Someone could get hurt.”

Izzy rolled her eyes. “It’s a good thing none of my younger brothers are here. I’d be worried about them with any kind of dangerous implement. I swear my eight year old brother could hurt himself on a fly swatter wrapped in toilet paper.”

“Good one,” Bryant complimented. “You look good in the cowgirl dress too.”

“It’s not overly comfortable,” Izzy complained. “I’d rather be in a pair of stretch jeans.”

Neal looked over and saw a man with a sheriff’s badge coming toward him, and noted, “This is a little too weird. I think it’s time for this dream to be over. It started with me putting on the hat. If I take it off, that should end it.” He took



the hat off, but nothing changed. The sheriff continued toward them.

“Careful,” Dallin warned. “This may end up being a nightmare.”